

connect the living area and outdoors, will serve you in the long term.

2. Fees and charges

Know the council rates for standalone properties, and the body corporate expenses for apartments and townhouses. Any shared aspects of the property and common areas, such as driveways, fences, security gates, pools, gyms and gardens, will need to be repaired, cleaned and maintained at the cost of the owners.

3. Included land

Just because a dividing fence, on the border between detached houses, is in a certain spot does not mean that it was correctly placed when the blocks were subdivided.

Ask the agent for the property's title – the outline of the land you will own if you buy – and compare the existing boundaries with what's on the title. If there are discrepancies – for example, some of the land is within your neighbour's boundary fence – you will likely need to go through a one-on-one resolution with your new neighbour to share the costs of moving the fenceline.

Beware: this can be a fraught, but not unsolvable, process. If your agent can't help you make sense of the title, a solicitor will.

Check this also for older units, such as art deco walk-ups and mansions that have been divvied into apartments, with advertised floorplans that show a courtyard accessed directly from your home and with an additional entry point for other residents. Don't assume that because it's in the floorplan in the listing that you have the right to it.

4. Walk through the property during the day, afternoon and night.

DAY: Look for whether there is ample natural light in each room, and if there is a pervading heat or chill throughout the property.

WEEKDAY AFTERNOON: If you are located near a school, arterial road or shopping hub, you'll want to know if this seemingly peaceful street turns into a thoroughfare of jostling, honking four-wheel drives.

NIGHT: Be on the alert for neighbourly noise, cooking odours, the temperature of the property and privacy – can your neighbour look directly into your bathroom from their upstairs living room?